

Chapter 3: *The Job Interview That Already Knew Her Name*

She got the interview.

It arrived like a miracle that didn't fully commit to being one.

"We would like to invite you for an interview..."

She read the email three times.

Then a fourth time, slower, like the words might change their mind.

Mia was already behind her.

"You see?" Mia said. "We are employable."

"I haven't even gone yet."

"That's details. Don't get stuck in timeline thinking."

"That's not a thing."

"It is in corporate environments."

She picked her outfit carefully.

Mia rejected everything.

Too formal. Too sad. Too "I have given up but politely."

Finally, she wore something simple.

Mia approved.

“You look like someone who has suffered but is still functional,” Mia said.

“That’s... not a compliment.”

“It is in HR language.”

The café where the interview was held was too bright.

Too clean.

Too quiet.

Everything felt like it had been placed carefully to make people behave properly.

She sat across from the interviewer, hands folded.

Mia sat beside her.

As always.

Relaxed.

Like she had been invited.

The interviewer smiled.

“Good morning. Thank you for coming.”

She nodded politely.

Mia whispered, “Don’t smile too much. It shows desperation.”

She ignored her.

The questions began.

“Tell us about yourself.”

She answered.

Carefully.

Practiced.

Mia occasionally leaned in:

“Add confidence.” “That sentence was weak.” “Don't say ‘I think.’ Say ‘I know.’”

She whispered back under her breath, “Stop helping.”

Mia smiled. “I'm not helping. I'm optimizing.”

Then something strange happened.

The interviewer tilted her head slightly.

“I see here...” she said, scrolling her tablet, “that you were referred.”

She blinked.

“I wasn't.”

The interviewer frowned slightly. “It says here you were recommended by Mia.”

Silence.

Her body went cold before her brain could explain why.

Mia, beside her, didn't move.

Didn't react.

Didn't joke.

Just... sat still.

That was new.

Mia never sat still like that.

"That must be a mistake," she said quickly.

The interviewer nodded slowly. "Maybe. It's just written clearly here."

She laughed nervously. "There's no Mia in my references."

The interviewer smiled politely again. "Of course."

But her tone suggested:

That's not what our system says.

On the walk home, she couldn't stop thinking about it.

"Mia," she said finally.

"Yes?" Mia replied instantly.

“Did you… do something with my application?”

Mia looked at her.

Too quickly.

Too prepared.

“No.”

She narrowed her eyes. “That was fast.”

“I like efficiency.”

“That wasn't efficiency. That was reflex.”

Mia shrugged. “You're overthinking.”

That word again.

Overthinking.

Mia's favorite word.

At home, she checked her email again.

Nothing unusual.

Checked spam.

Nothing.

Checked sent folder.

Clean.

Still—

the interviewer's words stayed in her head.

Recommended by Mia.

She turned to the kitchen.

“Mia?”

Mia was there.

Of course she was.

“What?” Mia asked.

“Have you ever… emailed someone for me?”

Mia sighed.

A long, patient sigh.

Like she was tired of explaining gravity.

“No,” Mia said.

Then, softer:

“Why would I need to?”

That night, she couldn't sleep.

So she did what she always did.

She looked for proof.

Photos.

Messages.

Old notes.

Anything that made Mia feel anchored in reality.

She opened her phone gallery.

Scrolled.

Graduation.

Old assignments.

Café pictures.

Then paused.

Zoomed in.

There was a photo she didn't remember taking.

Her at a café.

Laughing.

But the chair beside her...

was slightly blurred.

Like the camera refused to focus there.

She swallowed.

“Why does this keep happening?” she whispered.

From behind her:

“You’re tired.”

She turned.

Mia was sitting on the edge of her bed.

Casual.

Familiar.

But tonight, something felt different.

The air around her felt… careful.

Like Mia was choosing each word before speaking it.

“That interview was weird,” she said.

Mia nodded.

“It went well.”

“That’s not what I meant.”

“I know.”

Silence.

Longer than usual.

Then she asked quietly:

“Why did they say your name?”

For the first time, Mia didn't answer immediately.

That silence was heavy.

Not empty.

Heavy.

Then Mia smiled again.

But it didn't fully arrive in her eyes.

“Does it matter?” Mia asked.

“It does to me.”

Mia leaned back slightly.

And said something softer than her usual tone :

“Not everything that exists needs permission to be real.”

She didn't sleep after that.

And neither did the question.

Because somewhere deep inside her—

a new thought had started forming.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

Just persistent.

If Mia had always been here...

then why was the world only starting to notice her now?